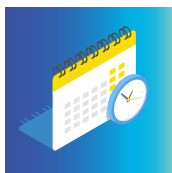




A STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE TO SUCCESSFUL CROWDFUNDING CAMPAIGNS

IN THE BLACK

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Following my previous article, which explains in great detail why and how your end-of-year campaign really begins in January (see “Why You Should Launch Your End-of-Year Campaign Today,” Compass Magazine Vol. 21, pp. 50-56), I will now elaborate on the end-of-year campaign itself, which takes place during the last three months of the fiscal year, October through December.

The end-of-year campaign is comprised of the following components:

- Collecting unfulfilled pledges that were made throughout the year
- Soliciting the mega potential donors who, for whatever reason, you have not yet solicited for their annual gifts
- Soliciting donors who have given a gift of at least one (or even half of a) unit in the past, but, for whatever reason, have not yet been solicited for the current year
- Creating a campaign to reach out to the mass potential donors—usually for less than half a unit each—also known as crowdfunding

This article will focus on key principles for conducting a mass campaign with the best possible results.

Crowdfunding is a general terminology for conducting a mass campaign. No matter which platform you use or what name you give it, the principles are usually the same despite the slight differences between them.

The common denominator of all crowdfunding is that of obtaining gifts from many people, helping you close your fiscal year in the black.

A WORD OF CAUTION

When launching a crowdfunding campaign for the first time, you must take into consideration the potential for its continuity during the same month each year for years to come—a crucial component to creating stability, consistency, and the ability to grow from one year to the next.

Some organizations will go all out in the first year of their campaign, setting a (relatively) high number for their goal. They will then work really hard to obtain two or three matchers who give 66 or 75 percent of the money, reach out to the rest of the community to obtain the balance—and hopefully achieve their goal.

Sometimes, though, in order to impress the mass donors—letting them know that each one of their dollars will be tripled—the mosad will “create” matchers, giving the impression that these donors are willing to give only if their donation will be matched. However, the reality is that some of these gifts are annual gifts given by those donors in any case, not new gifts to the organization. On the other hand, sometimes a shliach will succeed in actually obtaining (new) donors who are willing to give larger gifts than what they have given in the past because they are excited by this concept and the ability to create a buzz within the community—especially among the mass donors.

The challenge with both of the above-mentioned scenarios is that if they are not sustainable in the way they were done the first year, it will become more and more difficult to be able to continue running this campaign on an annual basis.

If you want to launch a one-time crowdfunding campaign for a very specific project, then just go at it, do the best you can, use whatever tactics work, and hopefully you will succeed. If, though, you would like to create within the community an annual crowdfunding event to take place each December, continue reading this article to gain the best insight into running an exciting, successful, and—most importantly—long-lived campaign with results that improve from year to year.

STEPS TO SUCCESSFUL CROWDFUNDING

In general, professional fundraising is based on a process, usually a long-term process, which grows from year to year. When done right, you begin to see good to great results even within the first year of launching any campaign.

The following are the key elements to successful crowdfunding—in chronological order.

1. Set the date—at least two full months in advance
2. Create lists of potential donors to be reached and solicited
3. Choose the type of campaign to be launched
4. Create a crowdfunding committee
5. Create a professional infrastructure
6. Free up your time from other major responsibilities
7. Commit to making this campaign a success
8. Conclude the campaign

Let us analyze each of the above items.



SET THE DATE—AT LEAST TWO FULL MONTHS IN ADVANCE

Like with any good campaign you would like to launch—a dinner, concert, walk-a-thon, raffle, etc.—the most

key element is to give yourself enough time in advance to do proper planning, as well as ample time to implement each of the stages—from the very first steps through the hours of the actual campaign. You will find it very difficult—if not impossible—to launch a successful campaign otherwise.

Since there is a lot of work to be done in a crowdfunding campaign and this type of work is very time consuming, you cannot cut corners. You must give yourself a good two months to work on this campaign—and actually get to work immediately—and maximize the time available to you.

When setting the date (preferably for sometime in December), you must take into consideration that the end of December is typically when people begin leaving town for holiday vacations. Of course, you must synchronize your campaign with Chanukah so you can maximize your Chanukah presence within the community before or after the campaign.



CREATE LISTS OF POTENTIAL DONORS TO BE REACHED AND SOLICITED

Once the date has been set, you will want to decide on the type of campaign and what your realistic and reachable financial goal will be. In order



to know that, you must first work on your lists. Only after a thorough research of the potential you have—based on reviewing your lists carefully, diligently, and honestly—will you be able to come to that conclusion.

The first list you will want to review is that of the donors who have contributed in one of the last three fiscal years (2016, 2017, or 2018) a minimum gift of \$1,000 (this number will vary from shliach to shliach but should equal one or more units) but did not yet repeat in 2019. These potential donors are the bread and butter of this campaign as matchers. They should be solicited as you have done in the past with a formal meeting, formal presentation, and firm ask with a high level of determination. Since you are doing this toward the end of the year, you are asking/suggesting for this donor to leverage his gift by adding his name and gift to the crowdfunding campaign, thus encouraging others to contribute as well, be it dollar for dollar or two for one or even three for one.

While reviewing this list, you may come across a donor who has given in the past but your feeling is that he most definitely has the ability to give (much) more. You can approach him and speak directly about the matching concept and ask him to give a



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much larger gift than he has in the past.

Be sure not to ask for too large of a gift if you are not sure you will be able to get other matchers or—if you are asking him to match dollar for dollar with the donations of the mass community—the mass community to match likewise.

Once you have finished going through this list, you will have an honest indication of how much you can reasonably expect to raise from this higher level of donors.

Now you can begin working on the list of your mid-level donors—those who have contributed in at least one of the last three fiscal years (2016, 2017, or 2018) a minimum gift of \$500 (this number will vary from shliach to shliach but should equal half a unit) but did not yet repeat in 2019. Some of these potential donors will require a personal meeting while many will be able to be solicited over the phone.

After you have created this second list, create a third list. This list will include the many names of all smaller level donors who contributed any minimum gift in one of the last three fiscal years (2016, 2017, or 2018) or even during this current year (2019).

Once you have created each of these three lists, copy all of

them into one separate, new file. In this file, near each donor's name, enter the (hopefully increased) amount you can reasonably anticipate receiving from this donor through a personal meeting or phone call. Then, add the amount of new donors you hope will participate in your crowdfunding campaign this year and the approximate sum you can realistically expect to receive from them.

The goal with creating all the above lists of potential donors for this campaign is to make them each grow both qualitatively and quantitatively. Qualitatively you want to ask each and every single donor to consider giving more than what he or she has given in the past, be it an additional 20, 50, or 100 percent, or even much more. Quantitatively, you want to increase the number of donors who participate in your campaign this year. Another crucial goal is for you to see on paper the realistic potential you have. This will give you a lot of new energy and the determination to make this campaign a success.

Now that you have created your lists, you can begin to reach out to your donors. Begin by reaching out to every one of the higher level potential donors during the first of the two months prior to the campaign. Begin with the one or two mega-potential donors and work your way down to the one-unit donors and finally even to the half-unit donors.

Once you have finished reaching out to all those potential donors, reach out to all those who donated to your crowdfunding campaign in previous years (and/or those on your lower-level donor list). You should call each of them and ask them to increase their donation from \$50.00 to \$100.00, from \$100.00 to \$180.00, from \$180.00 to \$250.00, etc.

Begin this process no later than at least two weeks before the campaign date. Hopefully you will have reached out to all or at least most of those potential donors before the campaign begins.

Your pitch to them should be as follows: since you are looking to increase the goal to a higher level than that of last year, you are personally reaching out to all those who gave in previous years and asking them to consider giving a larger gift than in the past. The fact that you as the rabbi are reaching out to them personally greatly increases the odds that they will agree to give larger amounts. Of course, you will let them know that on the day of the campaign their name and gift amount will appear on the campaign platform, thus encouraging others to give as well (though you can process their donation at the time of your conversation).

In total, you have given yourself a good six weeks plus to reach out to all or most of the potential donors and solicit them in advance of the campaign date. Now you and your volunteers are ready to reach out to new potential donors. By the time your campaign date arrives you and all the volunteers are really geared up and excited by the fact that a very large part (if not the entire sum) of the goal has already been raised. You are now either trying to reach the final stretch of the goal if you have not reached it yet or you are working to increase the goal.



CHOOSE THE TYPE OF CAMPAIGN TO BE LAUNCHED

After you have completed creating the lists of all potential donors on all levels and you have a good idea of

how much money you can raise from matchers and how much money you can raise from the entire community, you are now in the position to decide what type of campaign you would like to launch, as well as the financial goal you would like to reach. There are several variations to the crowdfunding campaign, although they all lead to the same goal: reaching out to the masses and obtaining larger gifts than you would otherwise have received.

CAMPAIGN VARIATIONS

- **Three to One:** You get three matchers to each give you \$10,000 (or any other amount) and then you raise another \$10,000 (or the corresponding amount) from the community, making your fundraising goal \$40,000.
- **Two to One:** Each dollar given by community members will be matched by another two dollars. With this campaign, you can create a goal based on the figures you already know you have a reasonable potential to raise, either from the matchers or from the mass community.
- **One to One:** Each dollar given by the mass community will be matched by another dollar from one or more donors (jointly).
- **No matchers:** This is simply a community-wide campaign to reach out to as many potential donors as you would like

Another variation in campaign type is its duration. While a 24-hour campaign may generate exciting tension and adrenaline, it may not give you enough time to reach all your potential new donors. A 72-hour campaign will give you more time but may lack the momentum that often fuels this campaign's success. Considering the number of potential donors you would like to reach during the campaign, as well the number of volunteers you will be able to round up will help you determine the campaign duration that is most suited to your circumstances.



CREATE A CROWDFUNDING COMMITTEE

It is very important to get as many members of your community as possible involved in your crowd-

funding campaign, as you will need many people to reach out to hundreds (or perhaps even thousands) of potential donors during the hours or days of the campaign itself.

You will do this by appointing a chairperson to create and lead a committee of volunteers who will reach out to community members, asking them to dedicate a few hours (or more) during the campaign to call and solicit potential donors. The more volunteers your chairperson and committee members

are able to round up, the more calls will be made and the more money you will raise.

The quality of your committee really depends on you. If you approach a high-caliber potential chairperson and share a full spread of preparatory work you have already done, as well as what you still plan to do before the campaign date, your request for his or her commitment to simply round up volunteers and encourage them to reach out to new people during the campaign is far more likely to be accepted than if the prep work would not have been done. A top-quality chairperson will likely create a top-quality committee, which in turn will b'e'zras Hashem lead to many volunteers and a successful campaign.



CREATE A PROFESSIONAL INFRASTRUCTURE

It is extremely important to have a professionally built infrastructure in place so that all pledges and

gifts are recorded, collected, and accounted for. While you prefer for all your donors to make their payments online at their time of pledge, there will be those, especially matchers, who might commit but not actually pay then and there. The pledges of those people must be recorded and then collected. Checks or cash given during the campaign must also be recorded and accounted for.

Of course, as soon as the campaign is over, a legal receipt and a thank you letter must be sent to all donors, letting them know the goal you had set and what you actually raised, as well as letting them know in what way the community has benefited as a result of this successful campaign.

Part of this infrastructure includes setting up a system where the lower level mass donors are reached at least four times during the upcoming year with an email or print publication that shares your mosad's news and upcoming events.



FREE UP YOUR TIME FROM OTHER MAJOR RESPONSIBILITIES

Like anything in life, if you really want to succeed you must dedicate the time truly necessary for

its success. The more you will invest the time you need for this campaign, the more successful it will be. As such, you must take a good look at your calendar and free yourself up from as many things as possible and allow yourself to invest all the time you can to make this campaign a big success.



COMMIT TO MAKING THIS CAMPAIGN A SUCCESS

In addition to freeing yourself up on the calendar, you need to make a commitment to yourself that you will invest the time, energy, focus,

and all you've got to make this campaign a great success. An

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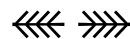
active commitment to yourself, your board, your chairperson, and committee members will go a long way. In addition to making your commitment internally, be sure to verbalize it to others. Stating something like “I’m truly committed to make this campaign a big success” is impressive and even contagious; it is exactly what you want from your chairperson, committee members, and volunteers. No matter their degree of involvement, you want them to give it all they’ve got.



CONCLUDE THE CAMPAIGN

After the successful campaign, make sure to schedule a meeting with you chairperson and committee members. At this meeting,

you will thank them properly for their time, commitment, and role in the success of the campaign. You will also be able to collectively review and share insight regarding each aspect of the campaign and determine what to build on or change for next year’s campaign. Conducting this meeting while the memories are still fresh will serve as an invaluable tool toward the success of next year’s campaign, b’eZRas Hashem.



We operate with the belief that “*uveirachecha Hashem Elokecha bechol asher ta’aseh.*” By following the eight steps provided in this article, we are investing all our efforts to create the best keilim for the Aibershter’s brachos. We pray for great success in our work. 🇮🇱